CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PLUMBER IN THE AI ERA

AI cannot crawl under a house at 2 a.m. and stop a burst pipe. Water damage doesn't wait for business hours, and neither does this paycheck.

★ TL;DR — Median around $75K — with journeyman and master plumbers and shop owners running well past it — on a 2–4 year apprenticeship road that ends in a state license. The catch: the road is long, the work is physical, and some of it is exactly as gross as you imagine. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

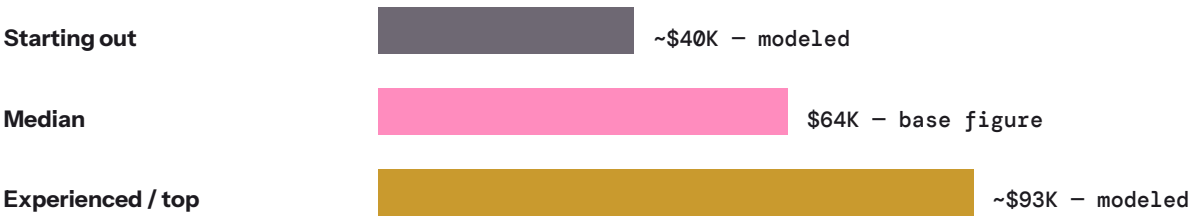
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$64K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- Works because: every building hides miles of pipe that leak, clog, freeze and fail on their own schedule — forever.
- Bites because: apprenticeship years are paid modestly and the license gate is real; there is no fast version of this career.
- AI angle: minimal. Software schedules trucks and writes invoices; it does not solder, snake, dig or diagnose by smell and sound.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Plumber is a ~$64K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PLUMBER ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Diagnose leaks, clogs, pressure problems and failing water heaters — often from a homeowner's vague description

✓ Cut, fit and join pipe (copper, PEX, PVC, cast iron), set fixtures, and run new lines in walls and slabs

✓ Clear drains with augers and jetters, camera-inspect sewer lines, and dig when the problem is underground

✓ Work to plumbing code, pull permits, and document the job for the customer and the inspector

Think: a surgeon for buildings, except the patient is flooding while you operate — diagnosis, steady hands, and consequences you can see immediately.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Estimating software, dispatch, invoicing and parts lookup. Cameras and sensors help locate problems — then a human still has to open the wall and fix them.	Everything physical and judgment-heavy: which fitting, which route, is this 80-year-old pipe safe to touch, and how do you tell a panicked homeowner the truth at midnight. Licensing law also reserves the work to licensed humans in most places.

⚠ **The apprenticeship is the filter: several years of early mornings, heavy work and journeyman supervision before the license and the real money. People who want trade pay without trade time should pick a different trade.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ A new location and a new problem every day — nothing like a desk ✓ Emergency work pays like it matters, because it does ✓ A license that travels and a clear road to your own truck, then your own shop	✗ Sewage, crawlspaces, attics in August, water in your boots ✗ On-call rotations come with service work — pipes burst on holidays ✗ Your knees, back and shoulders are part of the tool kit

Good fit? You're mechanical, unbothered by mess, and good with people on their worst day. You'd rather fix a real problem than attend a meeting about one.
Bad fit? You need clean, climate-controlled and predictable — or you expect top pay in year one. The license years are the deal.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — UNION APPRENTICESHIP (JATC)	DOOR B — NON-UNION SHOP HELPER → APPRENTICE
Apply to the local plumbers' union apprenticeship: paid on-the-job training plus classroom instruction over the 2–4 year band, with structured raises and the journeyman exam at the end. Competitive to enter, hardest to beat on total package.	Get hired as a helper/apprentice by a plumbing company, register your apprenticeship with the state where required, and log hours under licensed plumbers. More shops are hiring than unions are accepting — the license destination is the same.

Smart move: While apprenticing, learn the money specialties: sewer/drain, water heaters, repipes, or commercial work — and keep your own notebook of diagnostics. Specialists get the calls generalists can't finish.
Where you land after: Apprentice → journeyman → master plumber → own shop, or into commercial supervision and estimating.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
DECIDE YOUR	GET HIRED	WORK THE	LEARN DIAGNOSTICS	PASS THE	AIM AT

STEP 1 — Decide your door and apply early

FREE · TODAY

- Union apprenticeships open applications in windows that fill fast; non-union shops hire year-round. Apply to both.
- A driver's license and clean record matter — you'll be driving a truck into people's homes.

STEP 2 — Get hired as helper/apprentice

WEEKS

- Expect to carry, dig, clean and watch for the first months — that's the tuition everyone pays.
- Register your apprenticeship with the state board where required so every hour counts toward licensure.

STEP 3 — Work the apprenticeship years

PAID · 2-4 YRS

- Log supervised hours across service, new construction and repair — breadth makes the journeyman exam passable.
- Take the classroom/code portion seriously; code knowledge is what separates plumbers from parts-changers.

STEP 4 — Learn diagnostics, not just installs

ONGOING

- Camera inspection, leak detection, water-quality and pressure diagnostics — troubleshooting is the billable brain-work.
- Ask questions on every callback: revisits are the best free education in the trade.

STEP 5 — Pass the journeyman license exam

EXAM + FEES · STATE LICENSE

- When your hours qualify you, sit your state's journeyman plumber exam — written code plus practical elements where required.
- This license is the pay jump and the legal right to work independently.

STEP 6 — Aim at master license or your own truck

YEARS 3+

- Master plumber credential (more experience + exam) unlocks permits, bigger jobs and employing others.
- Business route: master license + insurance + a truck is the classic one-person shop starter kit.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: find your local union apprenticeship window and three non-union shops hiring helpers.
- □ Days 1–30: applications in everywhere; get basic hand tools and boots sorted; study pipe materials and fittings on your own time.
- □ Days 31–60: helper reps — carry, dig, watch, ask. Start a diagnostics notebook from day one.
- □ Days 61–90: confirm your apprenticeship is registered so hours count toward the license; learn your state's exam requirements.
- □ Day 90: you're inside a multi-year pipeline — employed, registered, and pointed at the journeyman exam.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **WATER FINDS A WAY. SO DO YOU.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.